

Perpetua Sarina Senatus

Dr. Palden Gyal

History of Modern China I – Policy Paper II

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Title: Advising Empress Dowager Cixi on Strengthening Women's Education in the Late Qing (1907–1908)

To (client): Empress Dowager Cixi

From: Perpetua Senatus, Imperial advisor and Confucian scholar sympathetic to modernization.

Question: How could Empress Dowager Cixi further promote women's education in the late Qing dynasty while maintaining Confucian moral and social order?

Date: Early 1908 (Beijing, China)

Introduction

Your Imperial Majesty, the question of women's education has become increasingly urgent as the Qing dynasty seeks to modernize while preserving Confucian order. The 1907 decree on girls' schooling marks a significant step toward cultivating women capable of supporting family, community, and state. However, concerns remain among elites regarding the potential for moral disruption or foreign influence. This policy recommendation outlines historical precedents, cultural considerations, and practical strategies to implement a structured, morally grounded system of female education that strengthens the empire, harmonizes modernization with tradition, and ensures social stability.

I. Historical and Cultural Context of Late Qing Reform

Before proposing specific policies, it is essential to recognize the broader context in which women's education must be advanced. The Qing dynasty faced pressing challenges from internal unrest and foreign pressures, highlighting the need for modernization while preserving social and moral order. Within this climate, educating women emerged as a potential lever for strengthening families, communities, and the state. At the same time, elite concerns about maintaining hierarchy, moral values, and cultural integrity shaped debates over reform. The following sections outline key historical, ideological, and institutional factors that must guide the design and implementation of female education.

A- Internal and External Pressures on the Qing state: Modernization and Moral Renewal

China's repeated defeats and foreign interventions eroded confidence in imperial authority, prompting reformers to modernize military, economic, and educational systems. Military modernization alone proved insufficient; the moral and intellectual foundation of society, particularly family structures, required attention. Within this context, women's education became both a leverage point and a source of anxiety, promising moral and intellectual cultivation while challenging centuries of Confucian norms. As Spence notes, late Ming theorists argued that educating women could improve morals, child-rearing, and household management (*The Search for Modern China*, 9). Reformers in the late Qing drew on this indigenous discourse rather than solely importing Western ideas, positioning women's education as foundational to social order and national strength.

B- **Confucian Gender Ideology and the Reinterpretation of Virtue**

Confucianism traditionally confined women to household management and moral guidance, fueling elite fears that literacy might disrupt hierarchies or introduce foreign ideas. Yet historical evidence shows that literate women engaged in household and social affairs without undermining family or state structures. By the late Qing, intellectuals like Liang Qichao argued that China's weakness stemmed from a lack of female education (Liang Qichao, qtd. in Qian 267). Educating women fulfilled Confucian ideals by producing virtuous mothers capable of raising enlightened sons, reframing female education from a moral threat into a patriotic duty aligned with state interests.

C- **Missionary Education and the Seeds of Reform: Models for Women's Schooling**

By the late 19th century, missionary and reformist Chinese schools introduced literacy, hygiene, and practical skills for girls. While concerns over foreign influence persisted, these schools demonstrated that women could be educated without compromising moral propriety. For example, Ida Kahn and Mary Stone, mission-school graduates, returned to China after U.S. medical training to establish practices, embodying the synthesis of moral ideals and practical education (Spence 109–210). The 1907 decree builds on this model, creating a centrally sanctioned system that safeguards Confucian values while advancing modernization.

II. Policy Recommendations

By framing education as a Confucian moral duty rather than a Western innovation, the imperial court could broaden access to schooling without undermining social hierarchies.¹ To achieve the dual goals of strengthening the nation and preserving Confucian moral order, I recommend a comprehensive policy framework for female education. This framework addresses structural organization, curriculum design, the integration of traditional virtue with modern knowledge, the cultivation of moral exemplars among educators, and the promotion of education as a patriotic and ethical duty. Together, these five measures provide a coherent strategy to expand girls' schooling while maintaining social stability, reinforcing family values, and advancing national renewal.

A- Establish a Hierarchical Network of Girls' Schools

As Charlotte Furth observes, late Qing reformers discovered that structured, state-supervised education eased conservative resistance to modernization.² Building on this insight, I recommend establishing a hierarchical network of girls' schools under direct imperial supervision. By mirroring the administrative organization of existing boys' institutions, central oversight in Beijing, provincial academies in major cities, and local branches in smaller towns, the court can guarantee moral discipline. Moreover, centralized regulation would prevent foreign or missionary influence from infiltrating the educational system, preserving cultural integrity while promoting intellectual advancement.

¹ Spence Jonathan D, *The Search for Modern China*, 3rd ed. (New York: W. W. Norton, 1999), chapter 11

² Furth Charlotte, "Intellectual Change: From the Reform Movement to the May Fourth Era, 1895–1920," in *The Cambridge History of China*, vol. 11, ed. John K. Fairbank (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983), 345–347.

This tiered system ensures moral oversight, gradual adaptation, and continuity from basic to advanced education. Aligned with the broader goals of the Self-Strengthening Movement, it demonstrates that reform and Confucian order can coexist, reinforcing the dynasty's moral authority and its leadership in guiding China's renewal.

B- Curriculum Design: Confucian Ethics and Practical Knowledge

Liang Qichao argued that women's education should serve the nation by reinforcing family virtues and loyalty, rather than imitating Western feminism.³ I recommend a curriculum that balances Confucian moral instruction with practical studies to cultivate both virtue and capability. Following Joan Judge's analysis of Shimoda Utako's Japanese model, the program should harmonize moral substance (ti) with practical function (yong), emphasizing loyalty, diligence, and modesty alongside literacy, arithmetic, hygiene, domestic science, and basic sciences.⁴

Ethical instruction should draw from classical Confucian texts, teaching filial piety, propriety, and civic duty, while practical lessons in childcare and physical education equip women for family and national service. This integrated approach ensures moral cultivation remains central, while preparing women to sustain healthy, educated households. By combining traditional and modern

³ Qichao Liang, "On Women's Education," in *The Birth of Chinese Feminism: Essential Texts in Transnational Theory*, eds. Lydia Liu, Rebecca Karl, and Dorothy Ko (New York: Columbia University Press, 2013), 189–204.

⁴ Judge Joan, *The Precious Raft of History: The Past, the West, and the Woman Question in China* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2008), 112–115.

knowledge, the curriculum produces well-rounded, virtuous, and competent women who strengthen both families and the state.

C- Balancing Virtue and Modern Knowledge in Women's Education

Building on Confucian ethics and practical skills, women's education should integrate traditional virtues with modern intellectual and occupational training. Reformers like Jiang noted that girls required education suited to their character and societal roles.⁵ I recommend emphasizing household management, financial literacy, alongside literacy, calligraphy, and basic arts, enabling women to exercise judgment within the domestic sphere.

Education should also leverage women's organizational abilities, patience, and meticulousness, strengths suited to professions such as primary education, accountancy, librarianship, and journalism. Modern skills and intellectual training should complement, not replace, the ideal of a "worthy mother and good wife."

Instruction in moral conduct and social behavior, grounded in the "four virtues" of Ban Zhao and early twentieth-century educators, will foster self-discipline, social responsibility, and practical competence, preparing women to navigate changing social norms while sustaining Confucian values.

⁵ Bailey, P.J. (2007). *Gender and Education in China: Gender Discourses and Women's Schooling in the Early Twentieth Century* (1st ed.). Routledge. pp 105-119

D- ***Training Female Educators as Moral Exemplars***

Historical precedent shows that elite women in late imperial China often embodied moral ideals that sustained family and state (Mann, *Precious Records*).⁶ Drawing on models like Zhang Xuecheng's "virtuous mistress," I recommend training female educators not merely in literacy or domestic skills but as moral exemplars whose conduct reinforces Confucian ethics in all aspects of schooling.

Teacher training should prioritize moral cultivation alongside pedagogical skill. Prospective educators should study Confucian classics on filial piety, propriety, and loyalty while learning practical education, hygiene, and management. Expected to embody humility, diligence, and restraint, teachers will model virtue in daily conduct, ensuring students internalize both knowledge and ethical foundations.

Trained educators should receive formal recognition as "instructors of virtue" within the national hierarchy, including ceremonial acknowledgment by local officials. Publicly celebrating virtuous teachers will encourage families to send daughters to school and demonstrate that education strengthens rather than undermines traditional hierarchies. By cultivating moral exemplars, the state can advance modernization grounded in virtue, ensuring reforms proceed without social disruption.

⁶ Mann, Susan, *Precious Records: Women in China's Long Eighteenth Century* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1997)

E- Promote Education as a Patriotic and Moral Duty

In his 1897 essay *On Women's Education*, Liang Qichao argued that China's weakness stemmed from women's lack of learning, which undermined family harmony and national progress. Building on this insight, I recommend framing female education as a patriotic responsibility, linking moral cultivation to national regeneration and transforming literacy into an act of loyalty to the state.

A nationwide campaign should promote the idea that “educating women strengthens the nation.” Public proclamations, school regulations, community lectures, and awards honoring exemplary households can highlight how literate mothers raise virtuous sons and maintain disciplined households, aligning education with Confucian ethics and reducing elite resistance.

Patriotic and moral themes should also be incorporated into the curriculum, including short moral stories, biographies of virtuous women, and lessons on national duty. Teachers should connect knowledge with service to family and empire, ensuring students understand education as both a moral and civic obligation. This approach secures public support, fosters disciplined citizens, and advances China's regeneration while preserving traditional values.

III. Addressing Objections

Even with carefully designed policies, reforms in girls' education are likely to encounter conservative, social, and financial challenges. Critics may fear that schooling will pull women

away from traditional domestic roles; this concern can be mitigated by implementing half-day schedules and integrating household-based lessons that reinforce domestic skills and virtues alongside literacy and numeracy. Some may worry that education might introduce foreign ideas of gender equality, potentially undermining Confucian values. To address this, Confucian ethics should remain central to the curriculum, ensuring that moral and filial principles guide all instruction. Additionally, apprehension over social disruption and the preservation of the inner-outer divide can be alleviated by maintaining gender segregation in schools and employing female-only staff for all teaching and administrative roles, thereby safeguarding propriety and traditional social norms.

IV- Addressing financial and administrative constraints

Successful implementation of girls' education requires careful attention to financial and administrative resources. The modest costs of establishing schools can be met by redirecting portions of local examination budgets, which will become less essential following the 1905 reforms. Resources freed by the abolition of the civil-service examinations can further support teacher training and the development of school infrastructure. To address potential teacher shortages, accelerated programs at normal schools can quickly prepare qualified instructors, drawing on educated widows and daughters of literati families to ensure a steady supply of skilled educators. This approach maximizes existing resources while providing a practical, sustainable foundation for expanding female education across the empire.

V. Conclusion / Expected Outcomes

Female education presents a critical opportunity to harmonize modernization with Confucian ethics and strengthen the Qing empire. By establishing a tiered, state-supervised network of girls' schools, the dynasty can ensure moral oversight, gradual adaptation, and continuity from basic literacy and household skills to advanced instruction in arithmetic, hygiene, and civic knowledge. A carefully designed curriculum that integrates Confucian moral principles with practical studies will cultivate women who are both virtuous and capable, prepared to sustain healthy, educated households and contribute to society. Training female educators as moral exemplars ensures that instruction extends beyond academics, embedding virtues such as filial piety, diligence, and propriety in daily practice and reinforcing social order. Framing education as a patriotic and moral duty further aligns schooling with national interests, demonstrating that literate, morally grounded mothers raise capable, disciplined, and loyal citizens. These measures collectively enhance family welfare, reinforce state stability, and preserve cultural continuity, showing that modernization need not conflict with traditional hierarchies. Guided by prudence, moral clarity, and careful implementation, this initiative can transform female education into a pillar of societal stability, promoting both the renewal and enduring vitality of the Qing empire.

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